

CROP CARE

Peaches and nectarines are self-fertile, so technically you do not need more than one tree in your garden to produce a crop. That said, the trees may benefit from a little help—if the weather is especially cold you may not be able to rely on insect pollinators. Gently transfer pollen from one flower to another using a small paintbrush.

Both fruits will need protection against frost, which may kill off their early blossoms. If your tree is compact or is growing against a wall, it will be relatively easy to protect with horticultural fleece. Alternatively, cover your trees with plastic sheeting over winter to keep them dry; this will help protect them from peach leaf curl,



Thin out fruitlets when they are young.

which may be transferred between trees by rain. Birds may also be a problem as fruit develops, so cover trees with netting to deter them. This may be problematic for freestanding trees, but attempt where possible.

Both peach and nectarine trees will benefit from being fed with a balanced fertilizer in late

TIP PRUNING AND TRAINING

If you don't want a freestanding tree, peaches and nectarines can be trained into fans on walls, or grown as bushes or pyramid forms—start from scratch with a feathered maiden or buy a two- or three-year-old pretrained tree.

Prune peaches and nectarines (along with other stone fruits) in springtime. The trees fruit on year-old wood, so prune to remove old wood that bore fruit the previous year.



Train your tree along wires to allow good ventilation and easy picking access.